Reproduced here in their original form, along with introductions that provide the historical contextualization and intellectual scaffolding needed to understand them in their entirety, the four debates between Nehru and his contemporaries together provide an intimate insight into the man and his ideas – as they took shape in the crucible of politics, squared up to the ideas of opponents and colleagues alike, and demarcated their position in the public realm. They give us a first-hand glimpse of Nehru in action, giving us an incisive view into the process through which his ideas came to triumph over those of his contemporaries and allowing a more composite picture of Nehru to emerge.

As many of the foundational questions Nehru was debating – the sanctity of the Constitution and the freedom of speech, the role of religion in public life, Muslim representation, the dynamic with China – have been resurrected as matters of raging dispute in India, and Nehru's legacy (and Nehruvian shibboleths) have come to be questioned like never before, revisiting these debates has become both pertinent and timely. It is instructive to note in this context how commentators and analysts, when making sense of

present-day situations, frequently turn to Nehru and to the debates with his contemporaries. In June 2020, for example, as a new Sino-India dispute erupted in the Himalayas, the Quint ran an article headlined, 'Would China Have Won in 1962 if Nehru Had Listened to Patel?'[15], testifying to the long afterlives of these debates and their ability to impinge on the present in multitudinous ways.

Today, Nehru may no longer be alive to answer his critics, but his ideas nonetheless remain locked in ideological combat, reviving debates that many had thought settled by history. In the heat of battle, they are frequently misrepresented or misinterpreted by all sides, not only because of partisan politics but also because Nehru, mediated through interlocutors, was many things to many people. As one of his biographers, B.R. Nanda, remarked, 'To the conservatives he was an extremist, to the Marxists a renegade, to the Gandhians a non-Gandhian, and to Big Business a dangerous radical.'[16] Nowadays, the list would be considerably longer.